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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

Coverage Date: 1950-1966

Place Coverage

G/wi, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): SOCIAL CONTROL

There are few hard and fast rules by which band judgment is guided. Hypothetical instances of incest and murder were immediately and unanimously condemned, but these offenses never occurred. Rape has been known, and here judgment sometimes went to the rapist because he had been provoked, and the girl was criticized for having started something she could not handle. Matrimonial disputes involving accusations of meanness, neglect, and adultery cause the most difficulty, and discussions have gone on for weeks before opinion crystallized.

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If the expression of a band's decision against him does not mend an offender's ways and he is impenitent in the face of the barbed comments of his joking partners, he will eventually be eased out of the band by means of a public conspiracy to keep him on the wrong foot. Carefully avoiding any behavior of which the offender could legitimately complain, band members put him through the frustrating treatment, such as not hearing him, misunderstanding what he says, and appearing to anticipate his needs wrongly, thus upsetting his plans. It is oblique and sometimes very subtle, and its effect is to make the offender so disgusted with them that he leaves for

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another band. It is a means of rejection which does not engender hostility, but only disgust and disappointment, and the offender is not left with a need to even the score or to carry on the conflict. In a new band, removed from the cause of his misbehavior and in a different atmosphere, the offender usually settles down to a normal, peaceful life. A small number of individuals, however, never settle down but move constantly from one band to another at intervals of a season, a year, or a couple of years. Their reputations are known to everybody and it is accepted that each band must have its share of putting up with them.

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The early detection of conflict and its treatment by means of a number of tension-relieving processes which reinforce cooperation and harmony reduce the need for elaborate devices of social control which depend on the imposition of sanctions. The versatility of social groupings and the lack of an inflexible set of precedents allow the bands a considerable measure of compromise and improvisation in meeting situations and there are few offenses of the species of crime against custom. There is only a small number of taboos and some of these are backed by a belief that breaking them will incur the wrath of the Supreme Being which could be visited on the whole community or the whole G/wi country. Potential offenders are deterred by their fear of the punishment itself and also by the anger of their fellows for having brought disaster on everybody. This idea of others being punished for the acts of one is also expressed in the doctrine of § 319 vicarious liability of parents for wrongs committed by their children (for example, destruction or damage of property) and the liability of one spouse for the other's acts. Group liability encourages group responsibility for the acceptable behavior of its members.

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